

# VAIŚEŚIKA

## Comprehensive Philosophical Notes

Based on Chapter 11 of C.D. Sharma's *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

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### I. Introduction

The Vaiśeṣika system is next to Sāṅkhya in origin and is of greater antiquity than the Nyāya. It may be prior to, and is certainly not later than, Buddhism and Jainism. The word is derived from 'Viśeṣa', which means particularity, or distinguishing feature, or distinction. The Vaiśeṣika philosophy, therefore, is a **pluralistic realism** which emphasizes that diversity is the soul of the universe. The category of Viśeṣa, or particularity, is dealt with at length in this system, and is regarded as the essence of things.

### Kaṇāda, the Founder

The founder of this system is Kaṇāda, who is also known as Kaṇabhuk, Ulūka, and Kāśyapa. This system is also called, after him, the Kāṇāda or Aulūka darśana. He was called Kaṇāda because he used to live as an ascetic on the grains picked up from the fields. *Kaṇa* (besides meaning 'grain') also means a particle or a particular, and the word Kaṇāda suggests one who lives on the philosophy of particularity — Viśeṣa.

Praśastapāda has written his classical *Padārthadharmasaṅgraha*, which is called a *Bhāṣya* or Commentary on the *Vaiśeṣika-sūtra* of Kaṇāda, but is really a very valuable independent treatise. It has been commented upon by Udayana and Śrīdhara. The Vaiśeṣika was, later on, fused together with the Nyāya, which accepted the ontology of the former and developed it in the light of its epistemology. Thus Śivāditya, Laugākṣi Bhāskara, Viśvanātha, and Annambhaṭṭa treat of the two systems together.

### II. Padārtha

The Vaiśeṣika system is regarded as conducive to the study of all systems (*Kāṇādaṃ Pāṇinīyañca sarvaśāstropakāraṇam*). Its main business is to deal with the categories and to unfold its atomistic pluralism. A category is called **padārtha**, and the entire universe is reduced to six or seven padārthas. Padārtha literally means 'the meaning of a word' or 'the object signified by a word'. All objects of knowledge, or all reals, come under padārtha. Padārtha means an object which can be thought (*jñeya*) and named (*abhidheya*).

### How Vaiśeṣika Categories Differ from Aristotelian, Kantian, and Hegelian Categories

The Aristotelian categories are the mere modes of predication and represent a logical classification of predicates. The Kantian categories are the moulds of the understanding under which things have to pass before becoming knowable. The Hegelian categories are the dynamic stages in the development of thought, which is identified with reality. The Vaiśeṣika categories are different from them all. While the Aristotelian categories are a logical classification of predicates only, the Vaiśeṣika categories are a metaphysical classification of all knowable objects, or of all reals. Nor are they, as the Kantian categories

are, mere moulds of the understanding. Nor are they, as the Hegelian categories are, dynamic stages in the development of thought. Hegel's is a philosophy of Absolute Idealism, a dynamic and concrete Identity-in-difference. The Vaiśeṣika system is a pluralistic realism, a philosophy of identity *and* difference, which emphasizes that the heart of reality consists in difference. It is a mere catalogue of the knowables, an enumeration of the diverse reals without any attempt to synthesize them.

## Bhāva and Abhāva; the Seven Padārthas

Originally the Vaiśeṣika believed in six categories, and the seventh, that of Abhāva or negation, was added later on. Though Kaṇāda himself speaks of abhāva, he does not give it the status of a category — it was raised to that status only by the later Vaiśeṣikas. The Vaiśeṣika divides all existent reals, which are all objects of knowledge, into two classes — Bhāva or being, and Abhāva or non-being. Six categories come under Bhāva, and the seventh is Abhāva. All knowledge necessarily points to an object beyond and independent of it (*na cāviśayā kācid upalabdhīḥ*; see Vaiśeṣika-sūtra, I, i, 15). All that is real comes under the object of knowledge, and is called a padārtha.

The seven padārthas are:

1. **Substance** (*dravya*)
2. **Quality** (*guṇa*)
3. **Action** (*karma*)
4. **Generality** (*sāmānya*)
5. **Particularity** (*viśeṣa*)
6. **Inherence** (*samavāya*)
7. **Non-being** (*abhāva*)

## III. Dravya (Substance)

Substance or dravya is defined as the substratum where actions and qualities inhere, and which is the coexistent material cause of the composite things produced from it (*kriyāguṇavat samavāyikāraṇam dravyam*). Substance signifies the self-subsistence, the absolute and independent nature of things. The category of substance at once unfolds the pluralistic realism of this system. Substance is the substratum of qualities and actions. Without substance, we cannot have qualities and actions, for they cannot hang loose in the air but must be contained somewhere. Substance is the basis of qualities and actions, actual or potential, present or future. Nor can substance be defined apart from qualities and actions.

Ultimate substances are eternal, independent, and individual, and are either infinite or infinitesimal. All compound substances (*avayavidravya*), which are made of parts and arise out of the simple ultimate substance, are necessarily transient and impermanent, subject to production and destruction. But simple ultimate substances, which are the material causes of the compound substances, are eternal and not subject to production and destruction. The dravyas are nine, and include material as well as spiritual substances. The Vaiśeṣika philosophy is pluralistic and realistic, but **not materialistic**, since it admits spiritual substances.

The nine substances are:

1. Earth (*pṛthivī*)
2. Water (*Ap*)
3. Fire (*tejas*)
4. Air (*vāyu*)
5. Ether (*ākāśa*)
6. Time (*kāla*)
7. Space (*dik*)
8. Spirit (*ātman*)
9. Mind, or the internal organ (*manas*)

## The Five Physical Elements

Earth, water, fire, and air really signify not the compound transient objects made out of them, but the ultimate elements — the suprasensible eternal partless unique atoms which are individual and infinitesimal. Ether is not atomic but infinite and eternal. These five are called elements (*bhūta*) and are physical. Each of them possesses a peculiar quality which distinguishes it from the rest. The peculiar qualities of earth, water, fire, air, and ether are smell, taste, colour, touch, and sound respectively, which are sensed by the five external senses. The external senses are constituted by the respective elements whose specific qualities are sensed by them — the sense of smell, for instance, is constituted by the element of earth, and so on. The elements are the substrata of these qualities.

## Time and Space

Time and space, like ether, are one each (*eka*), eternal (*nitya*), and all-pervading (*vibhu*). They are imperceptible and infinite substances, and are partless and indivisible; they are only conventionally spoken of as having parts and divisions. Time is the cause of our cognitions of past, present, and future, and of 'younger' and 'older'. Space (*dik*) is the cause of our cognitions of 'east' and 'west', 'here' and 'there', 'near' and 'far', and is different from ether (*ākāśa*), which is the substratum of the quality of sound.

## Ātman (Soul)

There are innumerable souls, and each is an independent, individual, eternal, and all-pervading spiritual substance. It is the substratum of the quality of consciousness. Consciousness is **not** the essence of the self. It is not even an inseparable quality of the self. It is regarded as an **adventitious** attribute possessed by the self — adventitious because the self does not possess this quality during deep sleep. The quality of consciousness must reside somewhere; it is not the property of the body, or the senses, or even of the mind. It resides in the self. Other important qualities possessed by the self are desire (*icchā*) and volition (*yatna*). Jñāna, icchā, and yatna are cognition, affection, and conation respectively. The fact that the self is the substance of these qualities is directly known through expressions such as: 'I know', 'I am happy', 'I want to do this', and so on.

## Manas (Mind) as a Substance

Mind (*manas*) is also regarded as a substance. It is the internal sense (*antarindriya*). It is atomic; but unlike the first four atomic dravyas (earth, water, fire, air), it does not give rise to compound objects. It is many, and each is eternal and imperceptible. Each self has a mind. It is the organ through which the self comes into contact with objects. Its existence is inferred from the fact that the self must perceive internal states of cognition, desire, and conation through an internal sense, just as it perceives external objects through external senses.

Moreover, in the perception of external objects, the mind is selective and active. We do not perceive colour, touch, taste, smell, and sound simultaneously, even though all the external senses may be in contact with their objects. Perception requires attention, and attention is the active turning of the mind towards the object of perception. Hence, in perception, the self must fix the manas on the object of perception with which the external sense is already in contact. Manas, therefore, is a substance, and it is atomic and partless, and can come into contact with one sense only at one time.

## Summary of the Nine Substances

These are the nine substances of the Vaiśeṣika. All of them are objective realities. Earth, water, fire, air, and manas are atomic and eternal. The first four produce composite things; manas does not. Earth, water, fire, air, and ether are the five gross elements. These and manas are physical; the soul is spiritual. Time and space are objective and not subjective forms of experience. Ether, space, time, and soul are all-pervading and eternal. Atoms, minds, and souls are infinite in number. Ether, space, and time are one each.

## IV. Guṇa (Quality)

The second category is guṇa, or quality. Unlike substance, it cannot exist independently by itself and possesses no quality or action of its own. It inheres in a substance and depends for its existence on the substance, and is not a constitutive cause of anything. It is called an independent reality because it can be conceived (*prameya*), thought (*jñeya*), and named (*abhidheya*) independently of a substance where it inheres. The qualities are therefore called objective entities. They are not necessarily eternal. They include both material and mental qualities. They are a static and permanent feature of a substance, while action is a dynamic and transient feature of a substance. A quality, therefore, is different from both substance and action.

It is defined by Kaṇāda as ‘that which inheres in a substance, which does not possess quality or action, which does not produce any composite thing, and which is not the cause of conjunction and disjunction like an action’ (Vaiśeṣika-sūtra, I, i, 16).

Kaṇāda mentions seventeen qualities, to which seven more are added by Praśastapāda. These twenty-four qualities are recognized by the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika school. It is not necessary to mention them all, as their importance is not much philosophical. They include material as well as spiritual properties: smell is the quality of earth; taste of water; colour of fire; touch of air; and sound of ether. Cognition, pleasure, pain, desire, aversion, and volition are the mental qualities which inhere in the self.

## V. Karma (Action)

The third category is Karma, or action. Like quality, it belongs to and inheres in a substance and cannot exist separately from it. But while a quality is a static and permanent feature of a substance, an action is a dynamic and transient feature of it. Unlike a quality, an action is the cause of conjunction and disjunction.

Action is said to be of five kinds:

1. Upward movement (*utkṣepaṇa*)
2. Downward movement (*avakṣepaṇa*)
3. Contraction (*ākuñchana*)
4. Expansion (*prasāraṇa*)
5. Locomotion (*gamana*)

## VI. Sāmānya (Generality)

The fourth category is Sāmānya, or generality. It is class-concept, class-essence, or universal. It is the common character of the things which fall under the same class. The sāmānya is more like the 'universal' than like the 'genus'. The genus stands for the class and includes the sub-classes or species. The sāmānya stands, not for the class, but for the common characteristic of certain individuals, and does not include the sub-classes. It is the universal by the possession of which different individuals are referred to as belonging to one class. It is called eternal, one, and residing in many (*nityam ekam anekānugatam sāmānyam*). It is one, though the individuals in which it resides are many. It is eternal, though the individuals in which it inheres are subject to birth and death, production and destruction. It is common to many individuals. There is the class-essence of the universal of man, called 'man-ness' or 'humanity', which inheres in all individual men. Similarly 'cowness' inheres in all individual cows.

Kaṇāda calls generality and particularity relative to thought (*buddhyapekṣa*). But this does not mean that the universal and the particular are mere subjective concepts in our mind. Both are objective realities. The system is staunchly realistic. The universal has as much objective reality as the particular. It is not a subjective class-concept in our mind, but an objective eternal timeless entity shared by many particulars and corresponding to a general idea or class-concept in our mind. The universals reside in substances, qualities, and actions (*dravyaguṇakarmavṛtti*).

### **The Higher and Lower Generality**

They are of two kinds, higher and lower. The higher generality is that of 'being' (*sattā*). It includes everything, and itself is not included in anything. Every other generality is lower, because it covers a limited number of things and cannot cover all things. A universal cannot subsist in another universal, otherwise an individual may be a man, a cow, and a horse at the same time. Only one universal subsists in all individuals of a class. What subsists in one individual only, like etherness subsisting in ether, is not a universal. Conjunction inheres in many substances, and it conjoins them, but it is not a universal since it is not eternal. Non-being is eternal and belongs to many things, but it is not a universal since it does not inhere in them.

## **Realism, Conceptualism, and Nominalism**

The three views of realism, conceptualism, and nominalism with which we are familiar in Western Logic appear in Indian Philosophy in the schools of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, Jainism and Vedānta, and Buddhism respectively.

| View          | School               | Position on the Universal                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Realism       | Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika      | Both particulars and universals are separately real, objective, and independent.                                                                                                                                                    |
| Conceptualism | Jainism and Vedānta  | The universal is not a mere name, but it exists apart from our mind only in the particulars, not over and above them; in point of existence it is identical with the particulars.                                                   |
| Nominalism    | Buddhism (Apohavāda) | Universals are only names, not reals; a cow is called 'cow' only because it is different from all objects that are 'not-cow' — it is a not-non-cow. There is no universal as a real; it is only a name with a negative connotation. |

The Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika school is an advocate of realism. It believes that both the particulars and the universals are separately real.

## VII. Viśeṣa (Particularity)

The fifth category is Viśeṣa, or particularity. It enables us to perceive things as different from one another. Every individual is a particular, a single and a unique thing different from all others. It has a uniqueness of its own which constitutes its particularity. It is opposed to generality. Generality is inclusive; particularity is exclusive. Generality forms the basis of assimilation; particularity forms the basis of discrimination.

It is very important to remember that the composite objects of this world, which we generally call 'particular' objects, are **not** real 'particulars' according to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika. Compound objects can be easily distinguished from one another by the differences of their parts. Thus no compound object, from the dyad to any gross object, is a particular in the technical sense. It is only in the case of the simple ultimate eternal substances, which are otherwise alike, that a need arises to postulate the category of Viśeṣa in order to distinguish them from one another. Thus, for example, one atom is similar to another atom of the same element, and one soul is similar to another soul. Now, how to account for their separate reality?

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, being a school of staunch realism, maintains not only quantitative but also **qualitative** pluralism. One atom differs from another not only in numerical existence but also in qualitative existence. The category of Viśeṣa, or particularity, is invented to defend this position, and the Vaiśeṣika derives its name from this. Each partless ultimate substance has an original peculiarity of its own, an underived uniqueness of its own, which is called 'particularity' or Viśeṣa. Viśeṣa, therefore, is the differentium (*vyāvartaka*) of ultimate eternal substances (*nityadravyavṛtti*) which are otherwise alike. There are innumerable eternal Viśeṣas. They distinguish the substances where they inhere from other substances, and they also distinguish themselves from other particularities. Though they, like qualities and actions, inhere in the substances, yet they are a distinct category. The Vaiśeṣika emphasizes realistic pluralism: atoms, souls, space, time, and manas all have their particularities.

## VIII. Samavāya (Inherence)

The sixth category is Samavāya, or inseparable eternal relation, called ‘inherence’. It is different from conjunction, or *saṃyoga*, which is a separable and transient relation and is a quality (*guṇa*). Samavāya is an independent category (*padārtha*). Kaṇāda calls it the relation between cause and effect. Praśastapāda defines it as ‘the relationship subsisting among things that are inseparable, standing to one another in the relation of the container and the contained, and being the basis of the idea, “this is in that”’.

The things related by samavāya are inseparably connected (*ayutasiddha*). It is ‘inseparable relationship’. It is eternal, because its production would involve infinite regress. It is imperceptible and is inferred from the inseparable relation of two things.

The things which are inseparably connected by samavāya are these:

- The part and the whole (*avayava-avayavin*)
- The quality and the substance (*guṇa-guṇin*)
- The action and the substance (*kriyā-kriyāvat*)
- The particular and the universal (*vyakti-jāti*)
- The Viśeṣa and the eternal substance (*viśeṣa-nityadravya*)

Samavāya is found in these: the whole inheres in the parts; a quality inheres in its substance; an action inheres in its substance; the universal inheres in the individual members of the same class; the particularity (*viśeṣa*) inheres in its eternal substance. Samavāya is **one and eternal** relationship subsisting between two things inseparably connected.

## IX. Abhāva (Non-Existence)

The seventh category is Abhāva, or non-existence. Kaṇāda does not mention it as a separate category; it is added afterwards. The first six categories are positive; this is negative. The other categories are regarded as absolute, but this category is relative in its conception. Absolute negation is an impossibility, a pseudo-idea. Negation necessarily presupposes some affirmation.

The Vaiśeṣika, being a realist, believes that just as knowledge is different from the object known, which exists independently of that knowledge and necessarily points to some object, similarly knowledge of negation is different from the thing negated and necessarily points to some object which is negated. Absence of an object and knowledge of its absence are different.

### The Four Kinds of Non-Existence

| Kind                     | Sanskrit          | Description                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Antecedent non-existence | <i>prāgabhāva</i> | The non-existence of a thing before its production. Has no beginning, but has an end — it ends when the thing is produced. |



|                          |                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Subsequent non-existence | <i>pradhvaṃsābhāva</i> | The non-existence of a thing after its destruction. Has a beginning, but has no end, since the same thing cannot be produced again.                                                                          |
| Mutual non-existence     | <i>anyonyābhāva</i>    | The non-existence of a thing <i>as</i> another thing which is different from it ('S is not P'). It is exclusion, opposed to identity. Both beginningless and endless.                                        |
| Absolute non-existence   | <i>atyantābhāva</i>    | A pseudo-idea: the absence of a relation between two things in the past, present, and future. Classical examples: the hare's horn, the barren woman's child, the sky-flower. Both beginningless and endless. |

Examples: a pot does not exist before its production; nor after its destruction; nor as a cloth; nor is there a 'liquid pot'.

Mutual negation, or anyonyābhāva, means the non-existence of a thing *as* another thing — 'S is not P'. The other three negations — antecedent, subsequent, and absolute — are called non-existence of correlation, or **Saṃsargābhāva**, which implies the non-existence of something *in* something else — 'S is not *in* P'.

If antecedent negation is denied, then all things would become beginningless; if subsequent negation is denied, then all things would become eternal; if mutual negation is denied, then all things would become indistinguishable; and if absolute negation is denied, then all things would exist always and everywhere. The view of non-existence is based on this ontological conception of the Vaiśeṣika.

## X. Atomism

Let us now consider the Vaiśeṣika theory of Atomism. Unlike the Sāṅkhya-Yoga, the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika believes in the doctrine of **Asatkāryavāda**, which means that the effect does not pre-exist in its cause. The effect is a new beginning, a fresh creation. Of course it presupposes a cause, but it is not contained implicitly in the cause, nor is it identical with the cause. The doctrine is also known as Ārambhavāda or Paramāṇukāraṇavāda.

The material objects of the world are composed of parts and are subject to production and destruction. They are divisible into smaller parts, and the latter are further divisible into still smaller parts. By this logic we have to accept the minutest particle of matter which may not be further divisible. This indivisible, partless, and eternal particle of matter is called an atom (*paramāṇu*). All physical things are produced by the combinations of atoms. Creation, therefore, means the combination of atoms in different proportions, and destruction means the dissolution of such combinations. The material cause of the universe is neither produced nor destroyed. It is the eternal atoms. It is only the atomic combinations which are produced and which are destroyed. These combinations do not form the essential nature of the atoms, nor do they pre-exist in them. Hence the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika advocates Asatkāryavāda.

### Qualities of the Four Kinds of Atoms

The atoms are said to be of four kinds — of earth, water, fire, and air. Ether or ākāśa is not atomic; it is one and all-pervading and affords the medium for the combinations of the



atoms. The atoms differ from one another both in quantity and in quality. Each has a particularity of its own and exists as a separate reality. The atoms of earth, water, fire, and air differ in qualities also; their qualities too are eternal.

| Element | Qualities of Its Atoms                  |
|---------|-----------------------------------------|
| Air     | Finest of all; possess touch alone      |
| Fire    | Possess touch and colour                |
| Water   | Possess touch, colour, and taste        |
| Earth   | Possess touch, colour, taste, and smell |

Besides these, all atoms have velocity, number, distinctness, etc. The qualities of composite products are due to the qualities of the atoms. The atoms possess the primary as well as the secondary qualities. They are said to be spherical or globular (*parimaṇḍala*). They are co-eternal with the souls and are the material cause of the world. They are inactive and motionless in themselves. During dissolution, they remain inactive.

## The Mechanics of Combination

Motion is imparted to them by the Unseen Power (*adr̥ṣṭa*) of merit (*dharma*) and demerit (*adharma*), which resides in the individual souls and wants to fructify in the form of enjoyment or suffering. They are supra-sensible. The atoms combine in geometrical progression and not in arithmetical progression; they increase by multiplication and not by mere addition.

When motion is imparted to them by the Unseen Power, they begin to vibrate (*parispanda*) and immediately change into dyads. A **dyad** (*dvyaṇuka*) is produced by the combination of two atoms. The atoms are its inherent cause; conjunction is its non-inherent cause; and the Unseen Power is its efficient cause. An atom is indivisible, spherical, and imperceptible. A dyad is minute (*aṇu*), short (*hrasva*), and imperceptible. Three dyads form a **triad** (*tryaṇuka*), which is great (*mahat*), long (*dīrgha*), and perceptible. And so on by geometrical progression, till the gross elements of earth, water, fire, and air arise.

The Vaiśeṣika Atomism is not materialistic, because the Vaiśeṣika school admits the reality of the spiritual substances — souls and God — and also admits the Law of Karma. The atoms are the material cause of this world, of which God, assisted by the Unseen Power, is the efficient cause. The physical world presupposes the moral order. Evolution is due to the Unseen Power, consisting of the merits and demerits of the individual souls, which want to bear fruits as enjoyments or sufferings to be experienced by the souls.

## Comparison with Greek Atomism (Leucippus and Democritus)

The Vaiśeṣika atomism agrees with the Greek atomism of Leucippus and Democritus in regarding the atoms as the indivisible, partless, imperceptible, and ultimate portions of matter which are eternal and are the material cause of this physical universe. But further than this there is hardly any agreement:

1. Leucippus and Democritus maintain only quantitative or numerical differences in the atoms and regard them as qualitatively alike. The Vaiśeṣika maintains both quantitative and qualitative differences in the atoms — the atoms of earth, water, fire, and air possess different qualities.

2. The Greek atomists regarded atoms as devoid of secondary qualities, while the Vaiśeṣika regards them as possessing secondary qualities also.

3. The Greek atomists believed that atoms were essentially active and motion was inherent in them, but the Vaiśeṣika regards the atoms as essentially inactive and motionless — motion is imparted to them by the Unseen Power.

4. The Greek view held that atoms constituted even the souls, while the Vaiśeṣika distinguishes between the souls and the atoms and regards them as co-eternal distinct entities, each possessing a particularity of its own.

5. The Greek view was materialistic and the evolution was thought of as mechanical, while the Vaiśeṣika view is guided by the spiritual and the moral law, and the later Vaiśeṣikas frankly admit God as the efficient cause.

## Comparison with Jaina Atomism

The Jaina conception of the atom, like that of the Greeks and the Vaiśeṣika, regards it as one, eternal, and an indivisible unit of the material elements. But it differs from the Vaiśeṣika view and agrees with the Greek view in that it maintains no qualitative differences among the atoms — the atoms are all homogeneous and become differentiated into heterogeneous elements by different combinations. Moreover, the Jains do not regard the qualities of the atoms as permanent, while the Vaiśeṣika does.

## XI. God

The Vaiśeṣika believes in the authority of the Veda and in the moral law of Karma. Kaṇāda himself does not openly refer to God. His aphorism — ‘The authority of the Veda is due to its being His (or their) Word’ — has been interpreted by the commentators in the sense that the Veda is the Word of God (*tadvacanād āmnāyasya prāmāṇyam*, I, i, 3; X, ii, 9). But the expression ‘Tadvachana’ may also mean that the Veda is the Word of the seers.

But all the great writers of the Vaiśeṣika and the Nyāya systems, including Praśastapāda, Śrīdhara, and Udayana, are openly theistic, and some of them — e.g. Udayana — give classical arguments to prove the existence of God. We cannot, therefore, treat the founder of the Vaiśeṣika as an atheist. Moreover, Kaṇāda believes in spiritualism and makes the physical universe subservient to the moral order.

The Veda is authoritative, but it is neither eternal nor authorless. It is the Word of God, and this makes it authoritative. God is omniscient, eternal, and perfect. He is the Lord. He is guided by the Law of Karma, representing the Unseen Power of merits and demerits. The Unseen Power is unintelligent and needs God as the supervisor and the controller. He is the efficient cause of the world, of which the eternal atoms are the material cause. Atoms and souls are co-present and co-eternal with God. He cannot create them. He simply gives motion to the atoms and sets the ball rolling. He is responsible for the first push, the original impetus, and then the atoms go on combining.

## XII. Bondage and Liberation

The Vaiśeṣika also regards bondage as due to ignorance and liberation as due to knowledge. The soul, due to ignorance, performs actions. Actions lead to merits or

demerits. They are due to attachment or aversion, and aim at obtaining pleasure or avoiding pain. If actions are in conformity with the Veda's injunctions, they lead to merit; if they are prohibited by the Veda, they lead to demerit. The merits and demerits of the individual souls make up the unseen moral power, the *adr̥ṣṭa*.

According to the law of Karma, one has to reap the fruits of the actions one has performed, whether they are good or bad, according to the karmas one performed. This *adr̥ṣṭa*, guided by God, imparts motion to the atoms and leads to creation for the sake of the enjoyment or suffering of the individual souls. As long as the soul will go on performing actions, it will be bound. To get rid of bondage, the soul must stop actions. Liberation comes through knowledge. When actions stop, new merits and demerits do not get accumulated, and old merits and demerits also are gradually worn out. The soul is separated from the fetters of the mind and the body and realizes its own pure nature. That is liberation, which is the absolute cessation of all pain.

The individual soul is treated as a substance, and knowledge, bliss, etc. are regarded as its accidental qualities, which it may acquire when it is embodied. Hence in liberation these qualities cannot exist, because the soul here is not connected with the mind (*manas*) and the body. Liberation is the cessation of all life, all consciousness, all bliss, together with all pain and all qualities. It is the qualityless, indeterminate, pure nature of the individual soul as a pure substance devoid of all qualities. The liberated soul retains its own peculiar individuality and particularity and remains as it is — **knowing nothing, feeling nothing, doing nothing**.

## XIII. General Estimate

### Overall Character: A Catalogue, Not a Synthesis

The realistic pluralism of the Vaiśeṣika is not a synthetic philosophy. It is a mere common-sense explanation and may, at best, be regarded as scientific analysis. The Vaiśeṣika gives us a mere catalogue of categories without making any attempt to synthesize them. Jainism, Sāṅkhya-Yoga, Mahāyāna Buddhism, and Vedānta mark an advance on Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika in this respect. Atomistic pluralism is no final philosophy, but it is an important stage in the development of Indian philosophy. It emphasizes scientific thinking and is an advance on the materialistic standpoint.

### The Seven Categories Cannot All Be Co-Equal

The Vaiśeṣika gives us seven categories and treats them as ultimate objective existents, the independent reals. But we are told that quality and action cannot exist without a substance and therefore depend on it. How can we, then, raise quality and action to the same status as that of substance? Universality, particularity, and inherence, being necessarily related to concepts, depend more on thought and cannot be raised to the level of substance. Non-existence is evidently relative, being related to existence, and so cannot be treated as absolute. The only fundamental category, therefore, is that of substance.

This substance too cannot be known in the absence of qualities and relations, and reduces itself to a mere 'I-know-not-what', a mere nothing. Again, this substance is divided into nine eternal kinds. Of these, ether is imagined only to provide a medium for the combination of atoms and to act as a substratum for the quality of sound, while space and time are intuitional, and mind is only an internal atomic organ. So there remain only the atoms of

earth, water, fire, and air, and the souls. It is absurd to maintain qualitative differences in the atoms. Hence the real metaphysical division of the reals should have been the physical atoms and the spiritual souls.

Jainism and Sāṅkhya represent an advance on Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika by bringing the material entities under one common category of Pudgala and Prakṛti respectively, though they too maintain spiritual pluralism in spite of their logic. The atoms, the eternal material points, must be united under one common category. And the account of the souls in Jainism and Sāṅkhya is much better than that in the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, for which the soul is a mere substance and not a subject, and consciousness is not its essence but only an accidental quality.

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1ZQNzr5sK35b7yJ3tkSIWYGktWMYFds8-/view?usp=sharing>

## **Negation and Inherence: Real Advances, Poorly Realized**

The acceptance of negation as a separate category and the recognition of inherence appear as two great advances made by the Vaiśeṣika. But the general atomistic and pluralistic and empirical character of the system takes away much of their importance.

The problem of negation is a very important problem of modern epistemology and metaphysics. The Vaiśeṣika recognizes the important truth that affirmation and negation, existence and non-existence, thesis and anti-thesis, presuppose each other. But it does not try to reconcile them in a synthesis. It does not feel the necessity of overcoming the conflict. Reality is a system where all contradictions are reconciled and dualism is sublated. The realistic pluralism chains the Vaiśeṣika to mere common-sense analysis and does not permit it to rise to the higher truth.

The same is the case with inherence. Inherence, or the inseparable organic relationship, is the pivot of the Vaiśeṣika system. The part and the whole, the particular and the universal, the quality and the substance, are inseparably related. The Vaiśeṣika logic points to the fact that the whole is not a mere aggregate of its parts, but is something over and above it. It is a Concrete Universal, an Identity-in-difference, a synthesis reconciling the thesis and the anti-thesis within its bosom. Inherence, really, is coherence. It is an organic and internal relation. And as such its importance can be realized only by Absolute Idealism. No pluralistic realism can rise to this height. And therefore the Vaiśeṣika has failed to treat inherence as an organic and internal relation, or as real coherence. In the Vaiśeṣika, inherence has remained only a partially inseparable and eternal relation and has not become internal, organic, and coherent.

The Vaiśeṣika maintains that though qualities cannot remain without substance, though a composite product cannot remain without the component parts, yet the substance can remain without qualities and the universal can remain without the particulars. In Vaiśeṣika inherence, only one term depends upon the other and is inseparable from it, but the other term can remain independent and separable from the first. But as a matter of fact, both the terms should have been regarded as mutually dependent and inseparable, and a need should have been felt to reconcile both the terms in a higher unity.

## **The Undeveloped Conception of Individuality**

Negation and inherence, being essentially the core of Absolute Idealism, could not be developed by the pluralistic and realistic Vaiśeṣika. But it could have developed the conception of ultimate particularity or individuality, from which it derives its name, consistently with its logic. Had it done that, it could have thrown some light on the problem

of individuation, which is a taxing problem for Philosophy. But here too the Vaiśeṣika has not done justice to this conception. It has merely hinted at it. Every atom and every soul has a uniqueness of its own. But what is that which constitutes this uniqueness? The Vaiśeṣika does not attempt the answer.

## Śaṅkara's Objections to Samavāya

Śaṅkara has pointed out the contradictions in the Vaiśeṣika categories. His objections against the Vaiśeṣika conception of Samavāya are fundamental and may be noted here:

1. The distinction that saṃyoga is a quality and samavāya is a category cannot be justified, because both are relations — one may be separable and the other inseparable, but this alone does not warrant assigning them to wholly different ontological orders.
2. Inherence, being different from the two things which it relates, stands in need of another inherence to relate it to them, and this second inherence requires a third, and so on *ad infinitum*.
3. If samavāya is not different from the terms it relates, then where does it inhere? If it inheres in the first term, it cannot relate it with the second; and if in the second, it cannot relate it with the first; and the same samavāya cannot inhere in both the terms, as it cannot be divided. Hence inherence is impossible.

The categories of the Vaiśeṣika are mere assumptions, and if we proceed with assumptions we may assume any number of categories we like, instead of six or seven.

## The Defects of Vaiśeṣika Atomism

The Atomism of the Vaiśeṣika is also highly defective. The qualitative differences in the atoms cannot be upheld. If the atom of earth possesses the greatest qualities and the atom of air the least, there should be a difference between their weight and magnitude. Moreover, if the atoms possess qualities like smell, taste, touch, colour, etc., how can they be eternal? And if the qualities of the atoms are eternal and cannot be separated from them, then why maintain that the qualities of the souls can be separated from them in liberation, and why maintain that the substance can remain without qualities? Again, if the cause transfers its qualities to its effect, then why does the atom not transfer its spherical nature to the dyad, and why does the dyad not transfer its minuteness and shortness to the triad, etc., which are regarded as great and long?

Again, if the effect does not pre-exist in the cause, then anything can be produced out of anything, or the effect itself may become like the hare's horn, for it is non-existent. Moreover, on the Vaiśeṣika hypothesis, there can be no creation and no dissolution. Are the atoms essentially active or inactive or both or neither? If active, then creation would become permanent; if inactive, then creation would be impossible; if both, the very conception is contradictory, since activity and inactivity, being opposed like light and darkness, cannot be combined; and if neither, then the activity must come from an outside agency. Now, is this agency seen or unseen? If seen, it could not be present before creation. And if unseen, then, it being always present near the atoms, creation would become permanent; and if the proximity of the Unseen Power to the atoms is denied, then creation would become impossible. In all cases, therefore, there can be no creation from atoms. It is no explanation of this world that it is due to essentially inactive, imperceptible, eternal, abstract material points. It is necessary to synthesize them and reduce them to one common source.

## The Degraded Conception of the Soul

The fate of the individual soul is worse still. The individual soul is regarded as a mere substance, and consciousness is regarded as its accidental property. The soul is treated just like an object; the object has really devoured the subject. The soul is essentially unconscious and is regarded as a mere substratum to receive consciousness, which may occasionally pour itself into it when the soul comes into contact with the body, the senses, and the manas. Any atom, as well, could have easily done that. And, like atoms, souls are regarded as innumerable, each having a peculiarity of its own.

Barring the Cārvāka position, which reduces the soul to a product of matter, the conception of the soul in the Vaiśeṣika is the most absurd and degrading in the whole field of Indian Philosophy. Even Hīnayāna Buddhism, though it has reduced the soul to a stream of momentary ideas, has retained the throb of consciousness intact.

## The Diminished Stature of God

The fate of God is no better. He is not the creator of this universe. Innumerable atoms and innumerable souls are co-eternal and co-present with Him, limiting Him and distorting His glory and greatness. He has been reduced to the status of a supervisor. And even as a supervisor, His hands and feet are chained by the shackles of the Law of Karma unfolding itself as the Adṛṣṭa. He has simply to pass on motion from the Unseen Power to the atoms and withdraw it when the time for dissolution comes. He Himself, without adṛṣṭa, cannot give motion to the atoms. In fact He has nothing vital to do with the souls. It is the Unseen Power of the merits and the demerits of the souls that starts creation.

The Vaiśeṣika system could have easily done away with a God. The liberated souls do not merge themselves in God, do not even share His knowledge and bliss, do not experience any communion with Him. Bhakti has no place in this system, since God is powerless to help or harm. The Vaiśeṣika does not maintain any internal relation at all: the atoms and the souls and God are all externally related to one another. As a matter of fact, though God is regarded as the efficient cause of this world, He is not even that — it is the Unseen Power which is the real efficient cause. If it is said that the Unseen Power, being unintelligent, requires the guidance of an intelligent person, and God is that, we may urge that God is regarded as the highest soul; and if the liberated soul is devoid of intelligence, God should also be devoid of intelligence, or He should be regarded as eternally bound, since it is only in bondage that a soul can possess intelligence.

## Liberation as Petrification

The Vaiśeṣika conception of liberation as the real state of the soul free from all qualities reduces the soul to a mere nothing. The root-fallacy lies in viewing the subject just as an object. To regard the soul as a mere substance is ultimately to explode it. The soul is nothing if it is not a subject and if consciousness is not its essence. True, the essence of the soul is not the empirical and relative and analytical intellect or understanding, nor is bliss in liberation identical with earthly happiness. Discursive intellect presupposes the foundational consciousness, the transcendental subject, and bliss in liberation transcends empirical happiness and pain alike. This truth has been forgotten by the Vaiśeṣika, and the result has been that we are offered a state of petrification as liberation.

*“It is far better to be born even as a jackal in the lovely forest of Vṛndāvana than to desire the liberation offered by the Vaiśeṣika.” — a Vaiṣṇava saint*

*varam Vṛndāvane ramye śṛgālatvaṃ vṛṇomyaham · na ca Vaiśeṣikīṃ muktiṃ prārthayāmi  
kadācana*

Śaṅkara calls the Vaiśeṣika the ‘semi-destroyer’ (*ardhavaināśika*) of this world, as opposed to the Hīnayānī Bauddha, who is the ‘full destroyer’. Śrīharṣa condemns the Vaiśeṣika philosophy as the real **Aulūka Darśana** — the owlish philosophy — since Aulūka darśana means the philosophy of Ulūka, and Ulūka is another name for Kaṇāda and also means an owl.

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*End of Notes · Source: C.D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter Eleven: “Vaiśeṣika”, pp. 175–190.*